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the over 500 varieties of grapes that the country produces and its wine culture, drive a couple of hours from Tbilisi to Kakheti, Georgia's great wine country, where vineyards spread across valleys beneath the Caucasus. It is the place to understand why Georgian wine tastes so unlike the European styles most drinkers know.

The key to Georgian wine is the *qvevri*. These large, egg-shaped earthenware vessels are buried in the ground, a method that naturally moderates temperature during fermentation and ageing.

Grapes ferment with their skins, seeds and pulp, including white grapes, creating wines that are deeper in colour, more tannic

and often more savoury and structured than conventional whites.

Georgians generally call them amber wines. In 2013, UNESCO inscribed the ancient Georgian *qvevri* wine-making method on its Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity.

Then there are the grapes themselves. Indigenous varieties such as Rkatsiteli, Mtsvane, Kisi, Khikhvi and Tsolikouri dominate many whites, while the inky Saperavi is its best-known red. Together with long skin contact and *qvevri* ageing, these varieties produce wines that can be floral, herbal, honeyed or dried-fruit scented, but also textured, acidic and distinctly food-friendly. They come alive beside the Georgian table: *khinkali*

(dumpling) filled with meat and broth, salty cheeses, tomato salads, and khachapuri—a traditional cheese-filled bread.

At the Giuaani Winery in Manavi, Kakheti, around 45 kilometres from Tbilisi, the family's winemaking history reaches back to the 19th century, with an old *qvevri* on the property dating to 1894.

Today, the winery works with a combination of *qvevri*, stainless-steel tanks, and oak barrels, making both Georgian-style and European-style wines.

Nika Tchitanava, Brand Ambassador and Sommelier at Giuaani, explains that the harvest runs from mid-September to late October, and is done by hand.

The winery has 36 *qvevri*, or clay pots, each holding 2,000 litres.